Magnolia Street

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32793829.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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by Enigm17a

Summary

Adora didn't want to attend this mandatory work function. She hated making small talk and she hated mingling with new people even more. Unless of course one of those new people is the gorgeous plus one of one of her coworkers.

~

Adora meets Catra at a work event

Notes

My attempt in contributing to the SPOP Creative Flex challenge. :) I seem to be incapable of writing angst recently. *shrug. My first time doing a challenge. Check out some of the other awesome authors who are participating!

See the end of the work for more notes

Adora tried to appear inconspicuous next to the open bar. These semi-regular firm functions at swanky hotels made her uneasy. She never felt polished enough, or smart enough or impressive enough. She hoped the glass of white wine she was drinking would relax her and assist with the anxiety she was feeling. Glimmer had said that attendance wasn't mandatory, however she followed that with a pointed look and an unsubtle observation about Adora's conspicuous absence from the last function. So she didn't think she had a choice in coming. So she riffled through her closet and found a decently formal white jumpsuit she could pull off with gold pumps and nice gold hoop earrings. She threw her hair up in a tight ponytail, adding a little hair poof to demonstrate effort and told herself she could leave the party at ten without anyone thinking twice about it.

She wasn't sure why she was so hard on herself. She was a hard worker, diligent and frankly, she was one of the best paralegals at this firm and she'd only been there a year. She was in demand, often the first staff member requested on any new case, and Angela, one of the senior partners at the firm, told her just this week that she was in line for a promotion by year's end. She knew all this and yet somehow, she still felt so awkward at these functions. She could draft pleadings and handle discovery like a pro but put her in a position to make small talk and she found herself completely floundering. Not much chance the lawyers, assistants, and other paralegals she worked with would want to talk to her about the importance of mixing up your gym routine or the latest issue of Mer-Mysteries. She should have taken Bow up on his offer to be her plus one, but she knew Glimmer wanted him to come with her and they'd all wind up hanging out together eventually, so it was fine. Except they weren't here yet and she was too sober to engage anyone by herself.

She took another sip of wine flashing back to her first firm social and her highly mortifying mix up with Micah Moonstone. Micah, better known as Glimmer's father, senior partner, and cofounder of the firm. She was new and hadn't met him yet. So when he came by in his tux offering to bring her and Glimmer some champagne,

she mistook him for waitstaff and handed him her hors d'oeuvre leftovers, informed him the bathroom was running low on toilet paper, and asked him to do a heavy pour on her champagne. When he walked away looking flummoxed, Glimmer just busted out laughing. After she explained who he was and made introductions when he returned with her almost overflowing flute of champagne, Adora almost melted into the ground in utter humiliation.

To this day Glimmer make a point of asking her father if the toilet paper was stocked in the bathroom.

She looked down at her half empty glass, internally pacing herself. She understood that wine was a delicate balance for her; she knew she needed to be tipsy enough to relax, but sober enough not embarrass herself again. She had a habit of being a little too forthright and handsy while drunk. Not something she was eager to demonstrate with coworkers. She glances at the doors to the entrance, willing Glimmer and Bow to appear. Instead, she spotted Scorpia, one of the paralegals she works with. Scorpia, an experienced team member with at least five years at the firm, was always very sweet and made herself incredibly helpful in her transition when she first started. She made herself available to answer all of Adora’s ridiculous questions and made a point of including her at all the support staff lunches to help acclimate her to the team. If Adora remembered correctly, she was dating one of the family-law attorneys, Perfuma. Perfuma, similarly to Glimmer, didn’t hold too much stock in the lawyer vs paralegal status bullshit that can often formed the social dynamics in a law firm. She was very friendly, albeit a little strange at times, offering to center her chakras on occasion, but made a point of including Adora’s input in any cases she supported. Adora felt relieved. These two were colleagues she wouldn’t mind spending time with. At least until Bow and Glimmer arrived.

She pushed herself off the bar and started walking towards Scorpia, smile ready on her face. But as she approached, Adora realized Perfuma wasn’t with her. Someone new, and frankly, incredibly attractive, was with her instead. Adora didn’t recognize

the newcomer. She was wearing a simple fitted maroon suit, which contrasted beautifully against her copper skin. Underneath she had on a simple white dress shirt with a black tie and black wingtip shoes. Her hair was cut very short on the sides with a curly mop on top. It was a combination of professional, stylish, and striking. A combination she herself often struggled to achieve. The stranger looked ahead to survey the room, laughing at something Scorpia was saying. Adora froze mid stride looking at her. Though staring was a more accurate description of what she was doing. So much so that she barely registered Scorpia seeing her and waving her hand in a friendly hello.

"Adora! Hey! I wasn't sure I'd see you tonight. I'm so glad you came." Scorpia approached, a happy grin on her face. "Let me introduce you to my very best friend, Catra." The beautiful stranger was suddenly standing in front of her. Eyebrow lifted in silent assessment of her. It made her want to run to the bathroom mirror to reevaluate her hair, clothing, make up and general life choices.

The silent evaluation appeared to make Adora mute. Think, Adora, think, she lectured herself. Should she speak now? You are in a formal setting, she lectured herself. Someone is being introduce to you. What's next? Offer a hand?

Adora aggressively extended her hand for Catra to shake. The sudden gesture could easily be taken as hostile. Catra looked down at her hand and then back at Adora's face and smiled.

"Hey, Adora," she said, all confidence and polish. Her smile turned into a brash smirk. She shook her hand. Her grip was firm but soft. Hand cool, in contrast to her own slightly sweaty, palm. Adora shook her hand aggressively in response. Catra lifted her brows in surprise. Letting go after a moment, opening and closing her hand at her side. Probably trying to get feeling back into her palm. Adora almost groaned at the humiliation. Thankfully, she didn't.

“Catra is a life saver,” Scorpia shared. “Perfuma was called away to do work on a case last minute and I just feel so awkward coming to these things stag. Catra saved me by volunteering to join with almost no notice! Boy, was I relieved I didn’t have to come alone. It always makes me feel a little self-conscious, you know. Who did you come with?”

Adora now felt twice as uneasy as she had a moment ago. “Um. Well. I kind of decided to come last minute too so I didn’t invite anyone…” She trailed off. Unsure of what to add.

Scorpia opened and closed her mouth a few times, looking a bit sheepish and uncomfortable at putting Adora on the spot. She started stammering, “Oh gosh, I’m sorry. I didn’t mean. I mean, it’s fine. To go stag I mean. You’re great. You don’t need a plus one. Not that you couldn’t get a plus one, if you wanted to. I mean. Cause you could! You’re really terrific. And super pretty. Oh, I probably shouldn’t say that at a work thing. That’s rude right? Or Harassment? Catra, is that harassment? Um.”

Adora put a reassuring hand on Scorpia’s arm. Her rambling strangely helped put Adora at ease, “Scorpia, it’s fine! Please don’t worry about it. I’m perfectly okay.” She smiled kindly to prove it. “Bow and Glimmer are coming soon and you’re here. I’m not alone.”

“Oh wow, yes, of course you’re not. And even if you were, like I said, you’re great.” Scorpia gave a little relieved smile. “Um. I think I need a drink. Wildcat, want anything?”

Catra rolled her eyes at the nickname and responded, “Yes, get me a Lagunitas IPA.”

Catra and Adora stood in silence for a moment watching Scorpia walking to the bar. She was now alone with this gorgeous stranger who must think she’s a lunatic for trying to attack her with a handshake. Adora took a thoughtful sip from her wine glass, willing herself to make competent small talk.

“So. Wildcat?” Adora asked, attempting conversation.

Catra smiled an adorable, self-effacing, smile. “Yeah, I haven’t been able to escape that nickname since college. She won’t stop, but it’s impossible to stay mad at her. But she’s the only one allowed to call me that though.” Catra said that very pointedly at her with a smile. Adora laughed at the warning. “So you and Scorpia work together?”

Work. Familiar territory. She could work with this. “Yes. I’m relatively new to the firm. I’ve been working as a paralegal here for just under a year. Scorpia helped me get acclimated. Made me feel very welcome. How about you two? You mentioned college, is that how you two know each other?”

For a moment, Adora thought she detected a slight blush on Catra’s cheeks. “Ah yeah, we played rugby together at FrightZone U,” Catra paused before finishing her thought, as if unsure if she wanted to disclose further, “aaand we might have dated for a hot second.” She chuckled a little as if remembering their origin story, “we are the classic girlfriends to best friends’ trope.”

“Ah,” Adora smiled. Feeling a little more comfortable. “Oh yes, I’m very familiar with that stereotype. Maybe not quite best friends, but I’d say there are an embarrassing number of ex-girlfriends of mine that have become close friends.”

Adora giggled a little as she stared off thinking of her many failed relationships turned friendships over the past five years. Two big ones came to mind. First there was Huntara, one of the first queer women she’d met in school. She seemed like the perfect first girlfriend material. They both liked weightlifting and followed the latest health food trends, they were both graduates of the foster care system, and enjoyed watching women’s basketball. Ultimately, they realized that just being gay didn’t mean they should be gay together. In fact, they had almost no chemistry. Instead they decided to do all the things they had been doing while dating, without the dating part. Which worked out much better for them both.

Mermista was wholly different. She was a fantastic diversion towards the end of her schooling. She'd needed a break from school and met her at a book club. She was snarky and sexy and seemed like a great counter point to Adora's laid back, stay in on a Saturday night dynamic. Unlike Huntara, their chemistry was amazing. Ultimately though, sexual attraction didn't win over basic compatibility and they agreed to end things before they started to dislike each other.

And finally, Glimmer also got honorary mention. She definitely got a vibe from her when they'd first met. She was Bow's best friend and he'd introduced them one night at happy hour. Glimmer told her about an opening at the firm and encouraged her to apply. This was before she and Bow finally got together. That night, she and Glimmer got drunk and almost made out in the alley outside the bar. Somehow, they each thought better of it, but that tension was there for a few weeks. She was so grateful nothing happened between them because Adora ended up getting the job Glimmer told her about and became her functional supervisor.

Adora glances over at Catra who'd been looking at her appraisingly; eyebrow raised again.

"What?" Adora looks down at her outfit, confused. Did she spill something? Why was Catra looking at her like that.

"Uh. Nothing."

Adora didn't buy it. She wasn't exactly a pro in social gatherings, but she could tell Catra was choosing not to saying something. Was she surprised she'd dated at all, or had friends? It was Adora's turn to raise an eyebrow, putting a hand to her hip in challenge.

"Just say it."

Catra laughed, raising her hands palm forward in surrender, "Okay, okay, to be honest. When you walked up, I kind of got a hetero vibe from you. Don't get me wrong, this outfit is hot,"

Adora nearly choked on her own saliva hearing this, "but I got a bit of a straight, rich, princessy air. The hair poof especially reminded me of sorority girls I used to know in college."

What! That's probably the funniest and least true thing that anyone has ever thought of her. It would be a little offensive if it weren't so ludicrous. It was almost fun to see the impression she'd made on someone brand new to her.

"Oh really?" she laughed.

"Mhm."

"I see. I didn't realize hair poofs had a sexual orientation. Or clothes. I'm also curious to know more about these sorority girls you used to know." Catra had the wherewithal to look chagrined. Adora continued, "You probably shouldn't assume so quickly. A tie isn't a required accessory in order to identify as queer in public."

Adora was shocked and pleased with herself. She was sparing with this beautiful woman. And managing to get a few shots in. And she wasn't even drunk!

"Yeah, sorry about that." Catra apologized easily, a hand rubbing at her neck ruefully. Adora couldn't help but find the gesture adorable. Catra accepted the criticism easily, offhand, like she didn't expect to be called out but didn't seem to mind that Adora had. Adora like that about her. "I'd say let me buy you a drink but…"

"…it's an open bar," Adora finished her thought. "It's okay, I forgive you. Though it's kind of funny you thought I had, what did you say? Straight, rich, princessy airs. Tell that to my never-ending college loans and very old, used car." Adora chuckled. It's not surprising Catra thought she was part of the rich elite here tonight. They were at a law firm function at one of the most expensive hotels in the city. She's sure whatever Angela Moonstone was wearing tonight would equal half a year of her salary. And Glimmer could have certainly chosen not to work after

she received her trust fund a few years back. Catra could be forgiven her assumptions. Even if it were more likely Adora couldn't even afford to rent a single room at this hotel

Catra laughed too, "Hey, well at least you have a car. I would have taken a bus or an rideshare here tonight if it weren't for Scorpia. And I have you beat. I have college loans AND law school loans that I'll be repaying till the day I die."

"I'll take your law school loans, and I'll raise you car payments and two part time jobs." Technically, her work with the youth center was a labor of love, but the spinning class she taught at the Y was 100% a job.

"Okay, okay. You win. I was wrong. I humbly admit my mistake, Princess." She said with a laugh and an exaggerated bow.

Adora laughed too, nodding her head slightly in acceptance of the bow. She felt at ease with Catra. Within a span of ten minutes, she had come out to her, overshared about her finances, and bantered! The anxiety she'd had about this party was slowly easing.

"You're forgiven counselor."

That honorific seemed to elicit a visceral response from Catra. She visibly swallowed, bit her lip, and seemed to get a little redder. Like she was slightly turned on. Adora noted that for later use.

Catra paused for a moment before responding, "Technically, you've just gave me a promotion. I won't be finishing law school for a few more months and until I pass the bar, I'm not yet a lawyer."

"Okay, but you're almost there. I still think it fits."

"Whatever you say, Princess." That nickname was starting to have an effect on her. She liked it. Which was weird. And now she was at a loss with how to respond. Maybe damned right? Or princess knows best. No. That won't work. Maybe she should drink a little

more. Avoidance is best. Adora went to take another sip of her wine, not realizing she had already finished it until she looked down into the empty space inside the glass, surprised. Fuck. Now she just looked ridiculous.

She was spared from responding by Scorpia returning to join them, followed by Glimmer and Bow.

"Look who I found at the bar." Scorpia said proudly, presenting Catra with her beer and surprisingly Adora with a fresh glass of wine.

"Thank you!" Adora said, grateful to have more liquid courage while talking to Catra. "And when did you two get here?" she asked, smiling at Bow and Glimmer, looking beautiful on each other's arm.

"Like five minutes ago, I waved at you, but you seemed too engaged with Catra to notice." Glimmer took pleasure in teasing her.

"Why Glitter! It's a pleasure to see you again." Catra did a mock bow.

"Horde scum, the pleasure is all mine. And you know damned well that's not my name."

Adora looked back and forth from Glimmer and Catra, "Um, I guess you two know each other."

"You can say that. We used to play against each other in college. Their rugby team called themselves 'The Horde.'" Glimmer rolled her eyes.

"Better than 'The Alliance!' What kind of weird ass name was that?"

"Weird enough to beat your ass plenty of times," Glimmer's voice started to rise.

“Oh boy, I did not think inviting Catra would cause such a stir. This was all so long ago. I thought we were all friends now.” Scorpia pleaded, uncomfortable at the conflict.

“Scorpia, come on now, we’re just playing. You know Glitter not so secretly loves me.” Glimmer rolled her eyes again in response. “Would someone who doesn’t love me help me get reference letters for law school.”

“I don’t love her, but there is no denying she has the perfect sharp tongue for a courtroom. She’ll make some murder suspect very lucky someday.”

“Why Glitter, are you propositioning me? Who did you kill and where did you bury the body?”

Glimmer, fed up with the exchange and mutilation of her name, rolled her eyes and muttered something about finding them all later abruptly left the conversation, leaving Bow behind to help broker peace.

“I think you two must have been related in another life. You fight like actual siblings,” he laughed, “I’m not sure why she lets you get to her. And you’re not fooling anyone, we all know you’re secretly friends. And don’t think you’re getting out of hosting game night, Catra, it’s your turn! I’ll be expecting your invite soon.” He put a comforting hand on Scorpia’s arm. “See, they’re fine. We’re all fine.” With that, he walked away to find his girlfriend. Leaving Adora with Catra and Scorpia.

“You two have a very odd relationship.” Adora noted out loud. She would have to ask Glimmer more about it later. She didn’t remember Bow or Glimmer mentioning Catra before. And definitely Catra does not strike her as someone who would host a game night. They clearly have a strange friendship. Glimmer was not used to people challenging her in any way. She was typically in charge of all conversations and not the butt of any jokes. It was a little funny to see her back down.

Catra laughed at Bow's retreating back, "Glimmer's actually alright. She's been pretty decent to me. She even got me an internship at your firm my second year of law school. But Bow's right, we can't help but snipe at each other. It's how we show our affection. Are you two friends?"

"She's kind of my boss, but yeah, I'd say we've become pretty good friends. Aside from Scorpia, Glimmer really helped me adjust at the firm. I hadn't had a lot of experience aside from getting my paralegal certification." And watching a lot of law dramas on tv. "She's surprisingly very patient when she wants to be. Bow introduced us and she encouraged me to apply for the job. Though, I think it's good she's dating someone completely outside of the legal world. I think being with a teacher mellows her out a little."

"Agreed," Catra nodded, "He's been a great influence on her. I'd say a few years ago, Glimmer would have thrown her drink at my face for using the wrong name. Right Scorp?"

"Oh boy, I don't know Wildcat. I think she's still likely to throw one tonight if you keep provoking her." Scorpia looked around as she was making that statement, hoping no one heard her bad mouth the boss's daughter. Adora swallowed her laughter. Scorpia probably wasn't wrong. Glimmer is well known for her temper. And at the same time, she is also an incredibly loyal friend. She'd probably get the towels to clean you off after she'd soaked you with her drink. It was fun to see Catra spar with her. Most people, not including Bow, were unsettled by Glimmer. In addition to being intimidated, so many folks liked to suck up to her and her family. Adora witnessed it firsthand many times. Their connection in the Bright Moon law community were well known. If you were a lawyer or law student, you wanted them on your side. Catra didn't not strike her as a sycophant who was either eager or nervous around the Moonstone clan. It was refreshing to witness.

Adora looked over at Scorpia to see if she still seemed worried. But it seemed that Scorpia had checked out of the conversation and was hyper focused on her phone.

“Hey, is everything okay?” Adora asked.

Scorpia looked up, surprised to be addressed. She blushed, “Oh boy. Sorry. I got a text from Perfuma. She’s wrapping up for the night and asked me if I could come pick her up. Which I… can’t.”

“Why not?” Catra asked.

“We can’t leave yet. We just got here. Right? I mean… she and I haven’t and um, she’s been so busy, and we could really use some time. But…I should stay…” Scorpia trailed off, struggling to construct a full sentence.

“Go! Seriously, go get your girl. You made an appearance; several people will attest to the fact that you were here.”

“I don’t know Wildcat, I feel bad. You came as my plus one and I feel like I’d be abandoning you.”

Catra gave her an exasperated look, “Scop, I’m fine. Glimmer and Bow are here, and I know a bunch of these assholes from when I interned and obviously Adora here will take good care of me. Won’t you, Adora?”

Adora blinked down at her. “Um. Yes?” Take care of her? Was she really talking about Adora! She couldn’t help the butterflies rushing to her gut at the implied double entendre. Stop being gross, Adora. She didn’t mean it like that!

Catra laughed at her. “See. I’m fine.”

“But how will you get home, I’m your ride.”

“Krytis is only a 25 minute rideshare away. I’m a big girl. Don’t worry about me.”

“If you’re sure…”

“Positive. Now get out of here and tell Perfuma I say hi.”

Scorpia set down her drink and practically ran out the door. Adora bit her lip thoughtfully watching her leave. It must be nice to have someone so eager to see you. She felt a small pang of jealously. Perfuma and Scorpia were very lucky to have each other.

"So," Catra started to say.

"So," Adora responded.

"So I hear you have a car."

"I do indeed." Adora smiled shyly and took another sip of her wine. Catra wanted Adora to drive her home. As in disclose her actual address, where she lives, eats and sleeps. As in share an intimacy, as in take their relationship from merely new acquaintances to possibly friend to possibly more? Adora's brain overloaded at the giant leaps it was taking. Catra was merely asking for a ride home, not some morning after breakfast. She was about to say something terribly cleaver along the lines of 'can I offer you a ride home tonight' when Catra changed the topic.

Looing around the smartly decorated event space, Catra pondered out loud, "I wonder if I'll know anyone else here tonight. Lonnie or Kyle definitely still work here right? And Rogelio?"

"Yep. Um. I think I saw them earlier." Adora scanned the room and saw they were where she noticed them at first arrival, in the back of the room, at the high-top tables. "There they are," she pointed in their direction with her glass of wine. She had spotted them laughing earlier at something one of them said. The three of them always appeared to be together. She supposed it made sense since they were all personal injury lawyers and from what she'd observed this year, lawyers seemed to mostly socialize by their field. She was sad that Catra was looking for an exit from their conversation. She had really enjoyed talking to her.

"So, um, I guess I'll see you later?" She started to say with a tight, polite, smile.

"Why. Are you going somewhere?" Catra asked. Surprised.

"Ah. No. I just thought…" Adora trailed off. Not sure what to say next.

"Thought you'd just abandon me at this party?"

"I mean no but…"

"But nothing. Scorpia left me in your care. I thought you'd take your hosting duties more seriously."

Adora was startled, was Catra serious? Was she somehow actually upset with her? She looked up at her and realized that Catra's eyes were twinkling, and she was seemed to be suppressing a smile at her expense.

Adora exhaled in relief. "My deepest apologies. How can I make it up?"

"You can escort me across the room."

Adora laughed, took another long sip of her wine, and offered her arm to Catra who took it with a grin. Her first thought was, she was fucked, Catra fit so perfectly on her arm. Like she was built to escort her. Second thought was, Catra smelled so damned good. Was it soap? Cologne? Whatever it was, it was subtle yet intoxicating. It made Adora want to bury her nose in her neck. Finally, she was starting to feel a little loopy from the wine. She has left tipsy and was rapidly moving to drunk. Which could lead to embarrassing choices. She knew she was a bit of a lightweight when it came to booze. She had gone out of her way to slowly nurse glass number one before starting glass two. Plus she'd eaten dinner. She looked down at her glass and realized she had a tiny bit left.

She should stop drinking. If she was drunk, she couldn't drive Catra home and she'd miss out on learning her address and spending that one on one time in the tiny Prius she called a car.

Lonnie spotted them as they approached. "Hi Adora. And Catra! What are you doing here?"

“Scorpia invited me.” Catra explained.

“Well hot damn, they’ll let anyone get in here.”

Catra grinned. Clearly this was an old dynamic. “Well after they hired you, all standards were lowered, so it would make sense they invited me to class up the joint.”

“Asshole! That was low.” Lonnie feigned looking hurt, putting a hand to her chest and mock fainting on top of Kyle.

“You know nothing’s too low for me,” Catra responded, wiggling her eyebrows suggestively. Adora’s could feel a twinge of annoyance. What was going on here? Were she and Lonnie more than colleagues? What was their story? This felt like flirting and Adora found herself feeling a bit jealous. Which was ridiculous. Catra could flirt with whomever she wanted. She was not her date.

Lonnie laughed, “Okay, okay. I get it. I missed you, you asshole. I haven’t heard anything from you in ages.”

“Law school, you remember how it is. Gotta finish strong and I’ve been studying my butt off for the bar exam.” Catra zeroed in on the short blonde, White guy actively avoiding looking at Catra. “Though I need to keep remembering that if Kyle passed, I’ll probably do fine.” Kyle turned a light shade of red around the neck and appeared to be studying his drink very carefully.

Rogelio, standing next to him, whispered something in his ear. Kyle gave him a tight smile in response. He seemed to be considering something and finally looked up at Catra and said, “Fuck you, Weaver, you’re damned right I passed. And on the first try. We’re all taking bets on how many times it’ll take you.”

Catra laughed out loud. Throwing her head back in delight and wiping a tear from her eye. She walked over to him and slapped him lightly on the back. “Touché, Kyle. You know I love you like a brother. A much, much younger brother, who’s got some growing

to do.” Kyle was half a head shorter than her and looked up at her with annoyance before flipping her off and walking to the bar.

Rogelio growled a little at Catra and followed him. Adora watched in confusion. Why the tension?

“Why do you always have to mess with him?” Lonnie rolled her eyes.

“You know why.”

Adora narrowed her eyes. Now she was genuinely curious about whatever happened and this whole dynamic as a whole. It almost seemed like Catra was bullying Kyle, which made her 95% less attractive, but it seemed like something else was happening here.

“That was over a year ago! And he tried to apologize.”

Catra snorted, “Like he would have meant it!”

“You know he would have. He made a mistake, he owned up to it eventually.”

Adora looked between Lonnie and Catra, willing one of them to elaborate. Catra finally exhaled and looked over to Adora to check for a reaction and explain.

“Mr. Kyle over there almost had me fired two weeks into my internship.” Adora gasped in surprise and looked over to Lonnie.

Lonnie exclaimed in frustration, “Stop being dramatic, you weren’t going to be fired!”

“Oh sure, they’d fire the second-year associate over the second-year law student.”

Adora was confused. Kyle, sweet, shy, scared of his own shadow Kyle, tried to get Catra fired? How? Why? She looked over at Catra, hoping she’d explain further.

“They weren’t going to get fire anyone! If Glimmer didn’t get fired when she pissed off Horde Prime, with over 3 million in annual billings, then you weren’t going to be fired.”

Catra rolled her eyes, “Glimmer, the daughter of not one, but two partners, didn’t get fired. I’m very surprised.”

Adora started to get a little uncomfortable. For no actual reason, she felt like she was going to be asked to take sides in this argument. And not knowing what happened, she didn’t like it. She hoped no one asked her to weigh in. Kyle seemed like a nice guy; he was always polite to her. In fact, he seemed perpetually anxious, something that she could related to sometimes. Catra, in the little time she’d known her, seemed like a high-speed train. Fast, competent, and capable of railroading anything in her way. Happily neither of them sought her opinion. Adora finished her wine just in case.

Lonnie exhaled sharply, “Why are you like this?! It was an honest mistake. And he tried to apologize to you.”

“Only once I called him out.”

“He would have done it sooner if he’d realized his mistake. Come on Catra, you know that. It’s Kyle!”

Catra relented, “I guess.”

“Catra!”

“Okay fine, it was a mistake.”

“You really don’t let go grudges easily. That’s a good thing to work on…with maybe a therapist.”

Catra looked like she was going to argue with Lonnie but finally relented, “Maybe.” Catra looked over at the bar to where Kyle and Rogelio were standing, avoiding their table. “Tell Kyle I’m sorry. I’ll stop fucking with him.” She grinned. “Mostly.”

“Fuck you, Weaver.”

“You two friend. I’m glad I ran into you. Let’s do happy hour when things calm down for me.”

“You’re on. First round is on me.”

“Second round too, you know I’m a broke law student.”

Lonnie laughed and nodded, turning to Adora. “Careful with this one. She’s feisty.”

Catra laughed and put her hand through Adora’s arm.

“Okay hostess, where should we go next?”

Adora blinked down at her. Catra wanted her to decide? She wasn’t sure what to suggest. She personally would like to avoid any more confrontation with any of her colleagues. But Catra seemed to know so many people, it seemed impossible to avoid them at the work party. Maybe they could somewhere private. “Um. Ah. I heard the view from the balcony is nice. Want to go check it out?”

Catra grinned, “Lead on, Princess.”

They went to an area of the balcony that seemed most removed from the party. There was a cozy two-person swing set up with a large faux fur blanket across the back. Perfect.

They sat down. Catra smiled at her after taking in the spectacular Bright Moon city view, “Good call.” She proceeded to cross her legs to remove one shoe, then the other. Curling up on the bench and looking over at Adora pointedly.

Adora smiled shyly and took off her pumps, enjoying the satisfying clunk they made as they hit the gravel floor, and curling her legs underneath her as well. There was a small chill in the air and Adora shivered a little. Catra reached behind them and wordlessly grabbed the blanket and laid it across their laps. Adora

almost swooned right there from the small chivalrous gesture, but happily she remained conscious. They sat there for a few minutes in comfortable silence. Adora couldn't remember the last time she felt this comfortable with a new…friend? She snuck a peak over at her. Being here, in quiet, she could comfortably admit to herself that she wanted Catra to be more than just a friend. She wanted to know her secrets, what made her tick, maybe hold her hand underneath this fluffy white blanket.

Adora cleared her throat, "So um, can I ask what happened with Kyle?"

Catra signed, "Do you really want to know?"

"Kind of, seems big enough that it bugged you for over a year. But only if you are up to telling me."

"Fair. Okay. I was assigned with Kyle when I first started. He was heavily involved in a medical malpractice case. It was a big one and had potential to be very lucrative for his client and the firm. The client was a widow whose partner was killed through a very preventable medical error. We really wanted to help her. And frankly, his enthusiasm was infectious. You've seen him, he never seems excited about anything. Except maybe Rogelio…and Lonnie I suspect." Catra grinned at that. Adora raised her eyebrows in surprise but didn't say anything. "Well anyway, I was helping him and miscalculated the statute of limitations on the case."

Adora gasped a little. Missing the statute of limitations would mean that they couldn't file a claim under the state tort claims act and thus the suit would be barred from being brought forward. Game over for the client and for the firm. And a colossal waste of billable hours.

Catra sighed, "You understand." Adora nodded. "Well anyway, it turns out the client gave Kyle the wrong incident date. The statue of limitations had expired before she even brought the case to him. He was never going to be able to pursue action. But before he figured that out, he blamed me for miscalculating the date. But

obviously, I had no way of knowing he had the wrong incident date."

"Of course not! I'm so sorry that happened. Wow, what a mess. Though sadly not totally uncommon."

"Yep," Catra emphasized the p. She rubbed her neck. "He was so mad at me at first and I was totally convinced that would be the end of my internship. But then he felt badly about it all and he did try to apologize. I was so pissed though and wouldn't let him."

"It wasn't your fault, and frankly it probably wasn't even his fault. Sometimes clients have faulty memories. It happens."

"Yeah. I know that. And it took me a while to really understand why I was so irrational about the whole thing and so angry. Surprisingly, Perfuma was the one who helped me process. I think she missed her calling as a therapist." Catra laughed humorlessly, "She helped me understand that I had, scratch that, have, a bit of imposter syndrome. I had only been working there a short time and was still reeling from the shock of landing this prestigious law firm gig. Me?! The almost college dropout, working at Moonstone and associates. An internship of this standing could virtually secure a dream job when I passed the bar. Anyway, I think it made it really easy to believe they'd can me if I made any mistakes, even if the mistake was out of my control."

Catra looked over at Adora, biting her lip. Adora smiled at as reassuringly as she could. It made her sad that Catra felt that way. And she appreciated that she felt comfortable enough to be this vulnerable. She understood the imposter syndrome all too well. Adora frequently felt the same. She thought about telling Catra about her crazy, fucked up childhood in foster care. How the imposter syndrome was the reason she'd barely graduated college herself. That she too had a bit of a shock at being hired to her position at Moonstone. A job like hers was in high demand, and even with Glimmer putting in a good word, there was no guarantee she'd get the gig. How she also aspired to practice law as well. Maybe at a public interest firm that promoted economic

justice for low-income families. But unlike Catra, she didn't know if she was cut out to be a lawyer and knew that financially it was truly impossible, so she never pursued that dream.

"I know all about imposter syndrome." Adora exhaled. She considered telling Catra all this, but it felt like too much to share so soon. Instead she decided to simply add, "It can be…hard…to overcome."

The corners of Catra's mouth slowly curled up into a smile. She kept eye contact for so long with her that Adora was sure she was about to be kissed. Instead, Catra reached over and brushed a stray tendril of blond hair behind her ear, making Adora's breath catch in surprise at the unexpected touch. She felt Catra's hand under the blanket, taking her own and giving it a small squeeze, before leaning back in the swing and looking up at the sky. Adora reminded herself to breath. She tried to assure herself that she could sit next to this beautiful woman and not make a fool of herself. Catra's revelation and vulnerability with Adora made her want to be a little bold.

So she took a deep breath, steeling herself before moving to intertwine their fingers together. Their hands fit well. The hold gentle and yet strong. Intimate. When she felt no resistance from Catra, she followed her example and leaned back against the seat, joining her in exploring the night sky. The view was clear, but the city lights meant they couldn't see any stars. Just dark grey sky. Adora wished she still had her old red pick up truck. She loved throwing blankets in the truck bed, driving out into the Whispering Woods and looking up into the brilliant canopy, just covered in celestial wonder. It was nice to fantasize about maybe doing something like that with Catra one day.

They sat in the swing for hours, or maybe it was just minutes. Catra put her head on Adora's shoulder. Adora tried to regulate her breathing, in, out, in, out. She didn't know how the evening progressed to this. But she was grateful it had. She hadn't felt so excited about someone in so long, she was starting to believe that

being single was just her status quo. But this witty, intelligent, stunning woman seemed to enjoy spending time with her.

Catra, head still on her shoulder, mumbled, "I'm glad Scorpia dragged me here tonight. I had a very exciting plans of studying BarBri books ahead of me. This is significantly more fun." Adora smiled, ecstatic to hear Catra say that. Sure no one would choose practicing for the bar exam to going out, but still, she knows it must be hard to give up precious studying time.

Adora unclasped Catra's hand so she could wrap an arm around her shoulder. Catra responded by moving even closer to her, her head under the curve of Adora's arm. Their bodies now touching.

Feeling more confident, "Okay, now that we've established that, we need to revisit another important topic." Adora put on a mock serious tone, "Earlier this evening, you mentioned I was hot."

Adora felt a little proud of herself. Cocky even. She was attempting to be flirty, verging on witty even. Some may call her assured. Normally she'd run and hide behind some glasses of wine when she was near someone that she found this attractive and hope they'd maybe find and engage with her. To be clear, it's not that she lacked self-confidence as a rule, she felt pretty good about herself typically. But engaging socially with new people was hard for her, initiating small talk especially was excruciating. Once she knew someone it was different, she could talk all night. Yet somehow with Catra, a near stranger, she felt at ease.

Catra lifted her head off of Adora's momentarily to say, "Mmm…I said the outfit was hot. I'd ask kindly that you not misquote me." She plopped her head back down.

"Ooooh, is that right?! Please accept my humble apology." Adora squinted her brow and pursed her lips in mock interpretation, "Hmm." She tapped her chin, "So to clarify, you're saying I'm not hot."

"I didn't say that either," came the muffled response from Catra.

“Then what are you saying, counselor?”

Catra plopped her head up in pseudo distress.

“Okay Princess. I didn’t realize I’d be subject to an interrogation this evening. Also, I didn’t say you weren’t hot. I was simply explaining that you twisted my words.” She paused as if for dramatic effect, “But if you’re asking, I think you’re very hot.”

Whoops. There it goes. All that confidence and bravado Adora had been feeling a moment before seemed to fly out the window. She had no idea how to respond to that. Catra outwitted her. Adora flushed beet red.

Catra seized upon her shock to ask casually with a smirk, “You feeling okay, Princess?”

Adora swallowed and nodded in the affirmative.
~

They eventually decided it was time to head out. It was well past the ten pm deadline Adora had set for herself. She made eye contact with Glimmer across the room from her as they made their way to the exit. Glimmer raised her eyebrows and dramatically tilted her head in Catra’s direction. Adora rolled her eyes and gave her a small wave goodbye. Glimmer grinned in response. Adora fervently hoped Catra had not noticed that exchange.

As they waited for the valet to bring her car around, Adora found herself shivering in the chilly night air. Like with the blanket, Catra wordlessly took off her jacket. Facing Adora, she gently wrapped it around her shoulders. Buttoning the top button at her collarbone, making it appear like a cape.

“There, now you’re officially a princess with your royal robe.” Catra whispered. Not moving away.

Adora took in the scent of Catra’s jacket and tried not to get too excited at being so close to the woman who it belonged to. She

liked it, both her scent and her proximity.

“I thought capes were for superheroes?” Adora asked quietly, mentally willing Catra not to take any steps away from her. She wanted to pull her in closer. Wrap her arms around the smaller framed woman. Would that be too much?

Catra pursued her lips thoughtfully. Adora couldn’t help looking down at her mouth when she did. “Well that’s also true,” Catra nodded sagely. “But this is a royal robe. And plus you can be a Superhero Princess.”

Adora put a finger to her mouth as if considering that, “Hmm. I think I like that. Adora, Princess of Power. Protector of the innocent, hero to the universe, savior of Etheria.”

Catra gave her a grin, “You’ve taken to this fantasy quite quickly, Princess.”

Adora grinned back, “Every little girl’s dream. Want to join me in saving the world?”

“I thought you’d never ask.”

Adora laughed.

The valet pulled up with her beat up old Prius. Adora slipped him a tip and opened the passenger seat door for Catra, “My trusty steed, Swift Wind, awaits.”

Catra groaned, “You did not name your car!”

Adora grinned foolishly back, offering a hand to Catra to guide her into the tiny-framed car. Of course she had to name it. How else would it know it was special?

“So chivalrous, Princess,” Catra threw her a grin.

Adora rolled her eyes and chortled in response, closing the passenger side door, and practically running to the driver’s side to

join her in the car. Even though they had just curled up next each other in the swing, having Catra in her car felt more intimate. More personal. She could see the chaos that was the real Adora. Hard to hide all that on no notice. There were no less than three empty take-out cups from smoothies and hot tea, the backseat had her embarrassingly bright, neon green, gym bag, the rearview mirror featured a rainbow Pegacorn she purchased this past summer at pride. Gratefully, Catra hadn't seen the back of her car which proudly displaying a cling of a rat lifting weights, and a "nobody knows I'm a homosexual" bumper sticker. This work event they just left showcased a relatively put together Adora. Sure, maybe a little shy and introspective, but relatively put together. Prius Adora was kitschy, messy, and wholly unsophisticated. Adora began to feel a little self-conscious.

She looked over at Catra and gave her an apologetic smile. "Sorry for the mess, I didn't expect company."

Catra paused to consider what she said, looking her in the eyes. She reached over to give Adora's hand a short squeeze and then a slow smile spread on her face. "Adora, first of all, I appreciate the ride. And second, I like your car. It smells like you." It was a casual enough statement, but Adora felt like she had been issued the biggest compliment. It smells like you. Like she liked things that smelled of Adora. Like she liked Adora. It made her buzz a little with electricity. The car felt a little less scary.

Adora willed herself not to sniff the air. She settled on buckling herself in and pulled out of the space. "Where can I take you, ma'am?"

Catra started giving her directions home. Aside from the occasional navigation, they drove in comfortable silence. Leaving the bright lights of downtown Bright Moon, moving to the relative darkness of the residential areas. Adora started to shrug off the jacket Catra gave her but realized that was near impossible to achieve while steering the car. She quickly abandoned the task to focus on the road. Catra must have noticed her short-lived struggle because she quietly reached over to help, giving her a

smile, and putting a guiding hand on the wheel. Silently offering to steer while she took off the jacket. This was a bit risky, yet Adora felt complete trust in Catra. Her foot eased off the gas. She quickly unbuttoned the top button holding up her 'cape' and removed it from her shoulders. All the while Catra navigated for her, her eyes fast on the road ahead, making sure to keeping the car steady. Adora returned one hand to the wheel, the other placing the jacket in Catra's lap.

"Thank you," Adora smiled gratefully in Catra's direction.

"Happy to help," Catra replied softly.

Adora reached over and gently took Catra's hand, sitting atop the jacket. She intertwined their fingers, and without taking her eyes off the road, brought Catra's hand to her mouth for a soft kiss. Holding it to her mouth for a beat or two longer before moving their hands to her lap.

She chanced a glance over at Catra and saw that she was a bit flushed. This obligation work event she didn't even want to attend had somehow magically transformed into a something amazing. There was touching, cuddling, sharing of life stories and now she was driving Catra home. This nondate was better than any first date she'd ever gone on before. Maybe because this wasn't a date, there was no pressure. It was evolving organically. No need to perform or make small talk. No expectations set ahead of time. She didn't have to stress about what to wear or where to meet or who would pay. Just two adults who seemed to enjoy spending time together. Catra was incredibly special. Even if Adora was not incredibly attracted to her, she could sense Catra was someone with a magnetic personality. She wanted to be around her all the time. Hear her opinions on food or music or recent Etherian legislation. She'd met her only a few hours ago but she felt a connection that seemed destined to exist. Like this meeting her was not accidental. Adora found herself going down a rabbit hole of daydreams about their future. Insane thoughts about sharing a bed, a home, a life together. She shook her head quickly. It was way too soon, Adora! Like U-Haul too soon. But another part of

her objected. It's not too soon to go after something that felt so special.

Adora was in such a driving daze, fantasizing about her life with Catra, that she completely missed the last turn Catra asked her to make. Crap! The neighborhood they found themselves in was a maze of one-way streets and tiny, aesthetically pleasing, though thoroughly impractical, street signs. After driving around for a few minutes Adora finally had to admit she was completely turned around and didn't know how to get them back on track.

"Um. I think I need to pull over, I have no idea where we are. Do you?" Adora looked over at Catra hopefully. Catra was peering out the window attempting to read the tiny print on the street sign.

"Hmm. It says Magnolia and Reed street. But, I'll admit, I don't know this area well. Let me get out the GPS on my phone."

Adora and Catra moved towards each other to huddle over Catra's map app. But after putting in her address, the tiny circle at the top of the screen kept spinning uselessly. It seemed the location was in a dead zone. No signal. No directions. No GPS.

Catra looked up at Adora with a rueful smile. "Sorry Princess."

"Oh please don't apologize. It's not your fault, I'm the one that got us lost." Adora let out an exhale. Running a frustrated hand through her ponytail. If she hadn't been busy daydreaming about what Catra might look like first thing in the morning, outside on their shared porch, with a cup of coffee in her hand, they might not in this situation. Adora could kick herself for throwing away the old map she used to keep of Bright Moon when she first moved to the area. After not using it for so long, she figured it was dated and let Bow use it for an art project with his students. And now, because of her, they were stuck in this random residential neighborhood in the middle of the night. She was loath to admit it to anyone, but for some reason, the burbs freaked her out. She preferred being either in a city, or in the middle of nowhere. The burbs felt somewhere like a scary in between. If

she dwelled on it, she started to think about every crazy horror flicks she'd been forced to watch where stupid white people died in the middle of suburbia.

Catra ducked her head so she could be in Adora's line of sight. "Hey. I can see you spiraling over there. Stop. I don't care that we're lost. I have no where I need to be and…" Catra smiled reassuringly. "I'm in the right car."

Adora bit her lip. Fuck. That was. That was quite the line. She felt a shiver going down her spine. Both from Catra's proximity and her words. She looked at Catra for a moment and glanced down at her mouth. She wanted to kiss her, wanted to close the distance between them, but she was holding herself back. Second guessing the situation. She should be thinking about how to get Catra home, not about tasting the garnet-colored lips in front of her.

"Hey Adora?" Catra interrupted her train of thought.

"Mmmm?" Adora cleared her throat, "I mean, yes?"

"I'm going to kiss you now."

Adora heart started racing at that. Like a teenager, the words *she's going to kiss me; she's going to kiss me* started looping through her brain. Catra took her time. Looking at her for any signs of hesitation. Finding none, she reached one hand to cup her face gently. She looked down at her lips and looked back into her eyes and smiled at her. That smile, coupled with her beautiful heterochromatic eyes, melted Adora. She licked her lips on instinct, partially opening her mouth before Catra kissed her. Catra saw and chuckled a little under her breath before finally saving Adora from herself and finally kissing her. Catra's lips were slow and tentative at first. Just her incredible mouth familiarizing itself. And wow, was it phenomenal. The sensation was exhilarating. Better then she would have thought possible for something so small. Adora couldn't help a little moan from escaping. Catra smiled against her mouth and deepened the kiss. Locking their

lips closer together, inhaling her expertly, moving deliberately and with purpose. Catra's mouth was gentle yet firm, yielding but in control. Advancing on her like she had trained for this moment. Adora happily let her take the lead, their mouths dancing together in exploration until she needed more than was being offered. Moving a hand to Catra's nape, she tugged possessively at the short curls to bring Catra's face even closer and opening her mouth to accommodate a deeper kiss, nudging Catra's lips apart with her impatient tongue. Without pause, Catra joined her, moving her palms to push against Adora's back, their mouths tangled up in one another.

Kissing Catra was exciting and unfamiliar. Like exploring a beautiful untraversed world. Yet, at the same time, it felt safe and comfortable. Like a warm blanket on a cool fall evening. The smell of her combined with the taste was exhilarating. She didn't ever want to stop.

They sat in the dark of the car, under the moon, exploring each other like time stood still.

Adora was the first to pull away. She took a deep breath and buried her face in Catra's neck. Groaning. "Fuck. That was phenomenal. I think we have a problem."

Catra ducked her face to look down at her in confusion. "What's the problem?"

"I don't think I'm ever going to leave the dark corner of this block. All I want to do is kiss you know. I think we're going to have to move here. How will I function doing anything else?" Adora lost all her filters. She almost wished she didn't know how exceptional kissing her would be because this is all she'd ever be able to think about. Well this and getting Catra into her bed. She was now in zero rush to drive Catra home.

Catra laughed. "Well we can work out a visitation plan, Princess. I won't make you go cold turkey."

Adora smiled up at her. “You promise?”

“I promise.”

End Notes

Promise kept.

Adora, with Catra's support, decides to give law school a shot. "Brightmoon and Associates" award her a grant to help her pay for it with a promise that she'll work for them for five years post law school.

Catra becomes a prominent lawyer in the product liability division. She successfully sues companies whose products hurt people, bringing forward multiple class action settlements.

Inspired by Magnolia Street, by Catie Curtis. She was one of my favorite artists when I first came out (aging myself).

Adora's White jumpsuit, Catra's suit, Gym Rat sticker.

Finally, for those of you following the The Set Up, I have not forgot about it!! Having a bit of writers block and taking a bit longer to finish up chapter 3. But please take a look at my tumblr. There you will find the RIDICULOUS graphic I spent too much time creating which gives you a hint at where the third chapter takes place. :)

I also created a dedicated twitter account. @enigm17a.

And as always, comments are my virtual Nutella. Helps me stay motivated when working through writer's block.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!